Informal Internal Communication

The work happening between formal messages

Informal communication includes spontaneous conversations, quick exchanges about work, social connection and digital chats. It is often treated as peripheral to internal communication, yet it can support coordination, relationships and employees' sense of belonging. The webinar combines research with practitioner experience to challenge the assumption that informal talk is mainly gossip or unrelated to work.

The academic study surveyed employees working in Germany and used factor analysis to group nine measured functions into four core functions: information and coordination; belonging and connectedness; stress management and recreation; and building personal relationships. All four were considered relevant, with information and coordination the most pivotal. The researchers report differences across groups: for example, personal relationships were more important to remote workers, while belonging and recreation were more important to younger respondents. These are findings from the study's sample, not universal rules.

Practitioner examples show how informal interaction can help leaders understand how messages are received and help colleagues solve problems. In hybrid and distributed teams, some of these opportunities may need deliberate support, such as creating time and spaces for casual exchange.

What this means for practice

- Treat informal communication as a useful complement to formal channels and a possible signal of employee concerns.
- Encourage opportunities for connection, especially for remote or dispersed colleagues.
- Listen with care, but do not try to control ordinary employee conversation.
- Use informal signals alongside other evidence; one conversation or visible online discussion cannot represent the whole workforce.

The session's central challenge for communicators is to make room for informal connection and learn from it without turning it into another managed broadcast channel.

Source: "Informal Internal Communication" transcript.